

Title

Airborne Risks Caused by Blowing Into Plastic Bags

Keywords

food hygiene, blowing into bags, food contamination, street food safety, Nigeria food vendors, bacteria transmission, plastic bag hygiene, safe food handling

Short Description

This article exposes the common habit of blowing into nylon bags before packaging food and explains why it's a serious hygiene risk. It explains how mouth germs contaminate food, why the practice persists, and the simple alternatives both vendors and customers can use to prevent infections.

Airborne Risks Caused by Blowing Into Plastic Bags

Some weeks ago, I stopped by a shawarma spot to grab a quick bite. Normal day, nothing special.

The guy making it brought out those thin nylon gloves they use. Instead of just wearing them, he blew into the gloves to open them, then slipped them on and started handling the vegetables.

I just stared. I had eaten from this spot many times, but that was the first day I actually *noticed* what he was doing. And something in me just went, “*No, this can’t be right.*”

After that day, I couldn’t stop noticing it. Everywhere I turned, I kept seeing the same thing: someone blowing into a nylon bag before putting food inside. Market vendors do it. Food sellers do it. Even at home, we do it too. Some people don’t think twice. Some know it’s not clean but do it anyway. Either way, we’ve all gotten used to it.

And that’s really what pushed me to ask myself: **How did we get here?**

Why is something so obviously unhygienic treated like nothing?

The Practice & Why It’s Widespread

From what I’ve seen, these are the main reasons it keeps happening

1. Pure Laziness and Convenience

It is faster to blow into a bag than to open it properly with clean hands or use a tool. Instead of doing better, many vendors choose the easiest and quickest option, even when it is unhygienic.

2. Customers Do Not Speak Up

Nigerians complain about stomach upsets, food poisoning, and the usual “*my stomach does not like outside food,*” yet many stand there quietly while someone blows germs directly into the bag their food will sit in. Silence keeps bad habits alive.

3. Poor Hygiene Mindset

Let us call it what it is. Some people genuinely do not see anything wrong with blowing into the same bag that will touch someone else’s food. It shows a lack of awareness and a lack of seriousness about hygiene.

4. No Proper Training, but Also No Effort to Learn

Many small food vendors have never gone through any food safety training. But in 2025, when information is everywhere from radio to WhatsApp, claiming “*I did not know*” is not enough. Some people simply do not prioritise learning better habits.

5. Habit Passed Down, Never Questioned

People copy what they saw others do. The problem is that instead of asking “*Is this safe?*” everyone just continues the cycle. Familiarity does not make something right.

6. Survival Mode Does Not Excuse Everything

Yes, times are hard. Yes, many vendors are doing their best with what they have. But there is a difference between struggling to make ends meet and ignoring hygiene. Customers deserve safe food, no matter the price.

What Happens When Someone Blows Into a Food Bag

[The human mouth is full of bacteria](#). Even a healthy person carries germs in their saliva, on their tongue, and in the tiny droplets that come out when they blow air. So when a vendor blows into a bag to open it, those droplets settle on the inside.

That is the exact surface your food will touch. From mouth to nylon. From nylon to food. From food to your stomach. That is the chain.

This is how foodborne infections, diarrhoea, stomach upset, vomiting, and general [gastrointestinal infection](#) can start. These germs come from bacteria commonly found in the mouth, such as Streptococcus and Neisseria, and are not meant to be introduced into food.

Because many of our foods are eaten immediately, hot, and without washing, there is no step in between to reduce the risk. The contamination goes straight from the vendor’s breath to your body.

It gets worse with moist or oily foods, which make it easy for bacteria to grow. Some vendors blow into several bags in a row, sometimes talking or blowing too hard, letting saliva land inside.

Every puff stacks more germs onto the next bag, raising the risk for anyone who eats it.

Simple Alternatives Vendors Can Use

The truth is, avoiding blowing into food bags is **not difficult**. It just requires a little awareness and the willingness to do things properly. Vendors have several options that are easy, cheap, and hygienic.

1. Use tongs or clean utensils

Instead of blowing to open a bag, vendors can use tongs, chopsticks, or even a clean knife to separate and hold the edges. It's quick, keeps the bag clean, and prevents germs from entering the food.

2. Snap or fold the bag open

Plastic bags can be opened by gently folding, snapping, or pinching the edges. It only takes a second and doesn't require any saliva. Simple tricks like this stop contamination before it even starts.

3. Wash hands frequently

Even if blowing isn't involved, food handling requires clean hands. Vendors should make a habit of washing their hands between customers, after handling money, or touching surfaces.

Clean hands plus clean packaging = safer food.

4. Use clean, separate bags for each item

Avoid stacking or reusing bags that have already been touched. Each new item deserves a fresh, uncontaminated bag.

5. Keep the food covered

Even when the bag is open for packing, keeping the food covered as much as possible reduces the risk of airborne germs landing on it.

What Customers Should Start Insisting On

The reality is, vendors often do what customers allow. If we keep quiet, nothing changes.

As Nigerians, we love our street food, but that doesn't mean we should accept carelessness. Customers can play a huge role in improving hygiene.

1. Speak up politely but firmly

If you see a vendor blowing into a bag, it's okay to say, *"Please, can you open it without blowing?"* Most vendors will listen when reminded politely. Silence allows unsafe habits to continue.

2. Observe before buying

Take a quick look at how the food is being handled.

Are the hands clean?

Are the bags handled carefully?

If it looks unhygienic, it's okay to walk away. Your health is more important than convenience.

3. Encourage hygiene in your household

Even at home, avoid blowing into bags. Children and younger family members copy what they see, so setting the standard at home helps break the cycle.

4. Be consistent, not selective

Don't overlook small shortcuts because *"it's normal."* Every time we tolerate unsafe practices, we allow germs to spread. Consistency in demanding safe food is what drives real change.

Remember, change doesn't start with vendors alone. It starts with customers refusing to accept unsafe practices.

Your insistence can make a big difference, not just for yourself, but for everyone eating from that stall or market.

Final Thoughts

Changing habits around food safety isn't about rules or lectures. It's about mindset, awareness, and personal responsibility. Every choice we make as a buyer, seller, or observer affects the standards we accept in our community.

Small, consistent actions can influence larger change, and the power to improve how food is handled is in all our hands.

I want to hear from you. Have you seen this happening in your area? What do you do when it happens?

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